

On Cinema

Don't Live in a Movie — On the Effects of Cinema Consumption

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Introduction

What is the pull of cinema? What makes us so moved by films and shows? What makes this medium enter so deep into the fibers of our soul, touch us, and then take up residence in our consciousness, merging into our perception and our language and shaping our world of concepts and feelings?

The influence of television and film consumption is well established by various comprehensive studies. Discussion often centers on the effects of violence, both because these effects are destructive and because they are relatively easy to demonstrate. Yet it is clear that the influence is far more comprehensive than that.

I want to open the discussion of the effects of viewing not from the sociological angle, but from the experiential angle of watching cinema (and for this purpose, and throughout the essay, I include narrative television programs in general as well). When the discussion is focused on statistics and broad social phenomena, it is hard to grasp the essential basis of these phenomena, and it is likewise hard to truly clarify what is problematic about watching. Any engagement with the various theories regarding the negative — or not — influence of the medium must begin from the individual's experience of viewing.

Let me say in advance — rather than piling up qualifications throughout the body of the text — that in the few pages before you I do not intend to survey the subject from every possible angle, nor to produce a detailed, refined and final accounting. My intention is to lay before you a few reflections on the matter, and although they are not comprehensive or systematic, this does not undermine their seriousness, or the grain of truth in them. Of course there is much more to discuss beyond my claims, and even regarding them themselves, but it is not my job to finish the matter, and I have come only to shed a few insights of my own on the subject.

The Power of Representation

As with every art form, in cinema we find a representation of parts of life. Every artistic genre operates in one facet or dimension of the reality of life: in photography and painting — the visual dimension; in dance — the dimension of movement; in music — the dimension of sound; and so on. What is special about theater and cinema is that they succeed in representing reality and life across the widest possible range of dimensions at once. Theater includes both a comprehensive sensory representation (sight and sound) at a high level of

fidelity, and also a time axis, which allows it to portray a plot, a story. It seems that herein lies its great power to create an immersive, engulfing experience and identification — it unites the advantages of prose (plot and the passage of time) with the power of the sensory arts.

The Dimness of the Present

One of the problems of life is the inability to experience prolonged time with strong, sharp intensity. This sentence can be understood by looking at the phenomenon of longing and nostalgia. When I recall, with longing, my high-school years, for example, and bring before my eyes images, feelings, memories and experiences from that period, I am not returning to a single, isolated point in time; in fact I am reconstructing an "accumulated experience," I am experiencing and remembering the entire period all at once. In high school itself I did not feel joy and satisfaction with anywhere near the intensity I feel now, because at a normal, routine point in time, the general emotional echo of the present is faint, pale and thin. Only afterward, when we gather all the tiny points of the experience of those years and fuse them into a single feeling of memory, only when we concentrate all the thin emotional impressions into one strong image — only then can we intensely feel the experience of the period. What produces the difference in the intensity of feeling is not the mere fact that it is past and will not return, but the fact that in longing we compress a long stretch of time into a single fraction of a moment, a single memory.

The same thing exists in the opposite direction as well, in anticipation of the future, in a dream, in a personal or collective vision of a whole reality. In this kind of general anticipation, reality is painted in emotional colors far more intense than what we experience day to day. One might even say (if we dare risk a bit of "homiletics" about reality) that the experience of a night dream gives us such a powerful feeling precisely because, in actual fact, the entire "script," the plot, unfolds in the brain within a few seconds. This is a compression of feelings onto a dense time axis, which sharpens the sensation and intensifies it.

Representation and Compression

In a film we receive a taste of concentrated feeling, through the concentration of the accumulated experiences of a long, ongoing plot into a small span of time. In film, the compression is done openly and unmistakably — the plot brought to the final cut includes only the details and events relevant to the theme, to the central experience of the film; only the "action" is shown.

Let us take a classic example: we watch a film in which the beloved, after agonizing and deliberating, decides to fly abroad in pursuit of his beloved. In reality, the time it would take him to reach her is at least ten hours, sometimes even a day or a week. In the film's representation, we see the actor in the very minute he makes the decision; immediately afterward we see a quick clip of brief scenes, set to rousing music, showing him packing his belongings, informing his acquaintances of the flight and driving to the airport; we watch

him board the plane with full energy, sit down in his seat with visible emotion and tension — until finally, after a prolonged experience of anticipation, resolve, excitement and fulfillment — which, in the viewer's actual reality, took at most three minutes — the plane lands at its destination, while the actor appears to remain in the same emotional intensity as the dramatic moments of life.

The illusion inherent, by its very nature, in this representation of the plot is clear. The film does not show us the process of packing all the clothes — which is hardly charged with emotion and anticipation; we do not get to see small, marginal details, such as the fact that the first bag wasn't big enough, or that our lovestruck hero forgot where he put the taxi company's phone number and was delayed ten minutes over it, which actually annoyed him quite a bit; the long hours of the flight, certainly not filled with vigor and dramatic vitality but rather packed with normality and calm, receive no cinematic representation. On the one hand, this feature is exactly what makes watching a film so much more delightful and moving than watching real, ongoing life, which "smears" its peak moments and peak experiences across a long stretch of time. On the other hand, the effect of this "illusion" on our lives can be weighty, and can exact a price in various areas.

As we grow accustomed to the world of cinema, we develop within ourselves an identification with the film, and, more than that, with the notion that it represents life. In other words, our thinking about ourselves and our lives comes to match the patterns of representation used by the medium. The implications are a shift in the perception or the inner psychic stance (not necessarily a conscious one) toward various matters. I will describe four such matters, in as general a way as possible.

1. Undramatic Time

As noted, a film mainly presents the "ecstatic" moments, saturated with tension or meaning. In light of cinematic representation, undramatic stretches of time seem unimportant — we do not perceive them as part of "our film," the film that constitutes the best representation of our lives. In this way, a qualitative ranking of our time is produced — time filled with vigor and dynamism is the central, important time, it is "life" itself, while the rest of the time becomes an appendage to life. Such a consciousness does not sit well with a consciousness in which small moral choices also matter, choices made not under the spotlight of vivid feeling but here and there, in some random or negligible fragment of the present. The belief that the service of God is an ongoing, continuous labor, the ethos of elevation and self-correction as constant awareness of one's deeds, thoughts, feelings and state of spirit — all of these can be harmed by the subconscious disregard for the mundane moments of life.

Beyond that, such a conception of life leads to an expectation of feeling a heightened, alert experience at all hours of the day. This expectation leads to a relative sense of boredom whenever a long stretch of time passes without any "exciting" event occurring. I am not naïve, and I do not think the concept of boredom was born with the invention of cinema. Still, the way we perceive and evaluate the moments of our lives has a considerable effect on the character of the boredom we experience.

2. The Length and Complexity of Emotional Processes

In real life, unlike what is usually shown in the cinematic medium, significant feelings and experiences accumulate and build up over time. Accepting the myth of the world of cinema can affect us and lead us to think that an event is intense and real precisely when it happens vigorously, overnight, in an acute emotional outburst.

One very typical example is the way falling in love is portrayed on film compared with how it really happens. In films, categorically, falling in love always appears as a process made up of a small number of scenes (even if we take, for this purpose, the majority of the scenes that exist in the film) — that is, made up of very little actual occurrence. It is difficult for a film to reflect, for instance, two people falling in love over the course of a year of knowing and interacting with each other. In reality, falling in love is often spread out over a long time, and it is not necessarily possible to point to two or three emotional turning points (the kind we would bring to a cinematic representation) that express the very fact of falling in love.

Another example is significant decision-making. A contrast and tension is created between what we consider correct and recognize from our own lives regarding the importance of settled, extended reflection about significant decisions, and the expectation that arises within us "to cut to the chase," to receive some unambiguous "revelation" of our inner will and to act upon it. This expectation stems, among other things, from cinematic myth. How could entire days of thinking and deliberation, of dilemma and reflection, be represented on screen? It is very typical for the medium to reflect a decision in a single, moving and impressive scene, leaving viewers with an impression of stable resolve and deep inner confidence in the choice that was made. In this, it does an injustice to reality, which for the most part contains more hesitation and doubt, and fewer decisions arising from full clarity of mind and complete self-confidence.

The same holds, generally, for experiences whose meaning, value and intensity are received through an ongoing process — such as forgiving another person, maturing, inner change, and the like — the cinematic representation of these will always remain incomplete.

3. Cumulative Experiences

Combining the two previous sections produces a lack of consideration for areas of life that are indeed not at the peak of feeling or meaning, but which are nevertheless formatively meaningful in their accumulation. Friendship with the kiosk owner, the regular charity set aside every week, the phone call to mom and dad, the regular writing on the forum — all of these are matters that will almost certainly never find expression in any creative framework, let alone in an artistic genre whose purpose is to wring out and arouse the fullest feeling of its viewers. But this too is an illusion. True, the act itself is not exciting, and we do not attribute to it any fundamental significance, but through its repetition so many times over the course of our lives, it becomes a cornerstone of personality, it takes on real

significance in shaping the character of our lives. Here too, cinema is too narrow a vessel to contain many of the meaningful domains of human life.

4. Inner-Spiritual Matters

A further domain that is very much missed by cinematic representation is the inner psychological and spiritual domain. Unlike prose, which contains descriptions of feelings, inner reflections and subjective sensations, the camera is bound closely to occurrences in the objective, material world. A director who wishes to give viewers information about a character's inner psychic occurrences must translate these sensations into fine nuances of body language, facial expression, and the like. In short, one could say that the entire plot is described "from the outside."

In this, cinema expresses, seemingly, a fundamental contradiction to the world of modesty (tzniut). The whole essence of modesty is that many psychic domains ought to be left in the private domain, and not every feeling that exists within us should be enacted and externalized. Thus, for example, a couple in love are asked not to express their love publicly through touch and special displays of affection. The modest person is inward by nature, he covers over his selfhood, and does not expose and express the whole of his emotional being. It will be difficult for the emotional complexity of the modest person to find expression in the cinematic medium.

This is not merely a problem on the plane of the virtue of modesty. In fact, this "externalizing" quality of cinema brings it to a very partial expression of human being as such. It is almost incapable of representing the full range of points of awareness, the inner voluntary struggle between good and evil, the optimistic point of view, shame, memory and nostalgia, yearning and longing, and a whole further spectrum of sensations and feelings that bodily (and even verbal-dialogic) expression is unable to properly describe.

One whole world, for instance, that is almost necessarily missing or absent from cinematic works is the world of "between man and Place" (God). The inner-psychic worlds of love of God, devotion and joy in God, and fear of God cannot be made accessible to the camera and the boom mic, cannot be converted into color and sound. Hence a creator who wishes to engage with a person's religious worlds is limited beyond measure. He will indeed be able to express halakhic commitment, the practical dilemma in places where the decision carries heavy weight and bears on religious-faith content, the sociological facet of being religious; but not the very heart of religiosity — the experience, prayer (the kind not measured by the intensity of one's swaying), the yearning, the inner dialogue, feelings of guilt, gratitude, humility, and more. The essential thing, the relationship between a person and his Creator — which, in the religious ideal (and for some of us, in reality too) is the essential matter of our lives — will always be missing from the film.

The implications of this externalizing quality arise mainly from a state of heavy consumption of this medium. We may come to internalize the inner logic of the world of cinema, in which something that has not been given expression and articulation does not

"exist" in the fullest sense, in which stirring events are precisely those that occur in the objective world (and not, say, in the reading of a fascinating matter or in an inner psychic turnabout), in which the externalization of feelings is what attests to their intensity, and so on. The great danger is that we will come to see ourselves as actors on the set of our own lives, and will strive to produce a successful "film," by the standards by which successful films are measured, the standards by which we ourselves measure them.

For all these reasons, excessive consumption of this medium distorts the ways in which we perceive various components of life.

An Impossible Harmony

On the other hand, just as it is possible and proper to find the root point of good in every broad human phenomenon, on the assumption that the various psychic forces are fundamentally positive, so too in the world of cinema, which certainly draws to itself a great multitude of viewers. As I cautioned in the brief introduction, I make no claim whatsoever to cover the subject comprehensively, but nevertheless, mainly in order to balance somewhat the picture I have drawn, I will dwell here on a certain point.

There are two kinds of art — one whose purpose is the representation of reality, and the other whose purpose is the realization of an aesthetic idea. Music, for example, does not describe anything that exists in reality, but only aesthetic ideas of harmony and beauty, in the domain of sound; dance — a representation of the aesthetic ideal of movement; poetry — of language and words. By contrast, sculpture and painting are a beautified representation of realistic materials on the plane of visibility, three-dimensionality and color; the story — on the plane of events, temporal sequence and development.

The genre of drama, and, in a more refined form, cinema, creates a mixing and unification of these two purposes. The main substance of a play or film lies in the script, in the realistic story that unfolds, presented to our consciousness through the senses of sight and hearing — ostensibly a distinctly realistic depiction which, like all the arts, is indeed beautified relative to reality, but still holds fast to it closely. Except that directors always also make use of music, and often also of song and dance. In this, the danger of illusion I spoke of grows from another direction — the mixing of representations of aesthetic ideas (like music, dance and song) with a representation whose concern is realia. The film creates a sense that reality answers to the rhythm of the background music, to the harmony of the song, to the beauty of the rhymes, or to the meaningfulness and clarity of the plot structure.

Yet it seems to me that alongside the danger, one can speak of a positive side arising from that very same direction — the illusion of the film's harmony. Both in terms of the combination of music, song and dance, and in terms of the classic modern screenplay structure, as expressed in Disney films or in Hollywood's more kitschy fare, cinematic representation portrays a goodness of a kind that limited, real reality is unable to contain. True, reality does not answer to a "happy ending," it does not grant meaning to all events, not even retrospectively, and it certainly, certainly does not repay the wicked according to

their wickedness. But if we are keenly aware of this basic, abyssal gap that separates reality from the film, then this sober experience of illusion can actually bring about a certain inner refinement, an elevation of the powers of imagination, and a supply of will driven by vision and trust. The cinematic instrument allows us to stretch the horizons of the soul and the imagination toward a higher good, toward the ideal and toward happiness. It is capable of establishing, in this way, optimism, trust in the good, trust in reality, in life, trust in the psychic capacity to contain harmony and tranquility, to feel love and happiness.

Judging Involvement

Another point at which an advantage and a virtue can be found in the cinematic medium, as a friend of mine illuminated for me, is its successful containment of the opposites of identification and reflection. The film grants a very powerful experience, and the viewer experiences the film as one identifying with it, as present in the place, in the situation, in the feeling and in the dilemma; yet at the same time, unlike in his own life, here he has the ability to establish a stronger reflection, a critique and an existential examination of the characters, of the actions, of the way of life and of the society and culture. The medium strengthens a person's capacity for judgment, in that he stands unbiased and unembarrassed before the fictional character; he can see its flaws, its shortcomings and its merits in a clear and direct light, without the masking of social feelings such as love, aversion, friendship, jealousy, and so on. Unlike a discussion or critique of another kind, the possibility of avoiding judgment of the external facet is actually greater here, since we are compelled to feel the depth of the complex emotional and psychic situation, because we entered it as identifying (and even somewhat empathetic, though to a degree that still allows the preservation of objectivity) viewers, and not merely as onlookers from the side and from without.

The Pleasure

Indeed, the obvious advantage is the great pleasure that watching a film provides. Here too one must understand that this is not merely a shallow pleasure. Film allows for a genuine broadening of the mind — it offers the opportunity to experience experiences that do not exist in your own personal life, and which may not even exist at all within our limited reality; it provides passage into new, or old, or unknown regions of the soul, and broadens the horizons of feeling. There is here a unique kind of development of the life-force, the sensing, experiencing force.

A Personal Conclusion

It is well known and clear to anyone who has spent time in our study hall that in every experience or activity there is chaff, that everything has its price. The central claim for whose sake I wrote this essay is that awareness of the illusory effect of film already softens the results of watching it. This awareness protects us from importing content from the world of cinema into our own value-spiritual world (which relates, in general, to our attachment to secular-Western-Israeli culture).

On the other hand, these insights (and others) have indeed led me to reduce my own film-watching, so that the place I consider fitting for watching television and films is that of a departure from the ordinary daily routine. That is to say, for me, watching a film is an unroutine event (even something of a festive occasion), and I do think it is unhealthy to "binge" on films, since this disrupts the healthy proportions between reality and concrete, actual life, on the one hand, and representation, imagination and illusion (which are not bad in themselves), on the other. And yes, it is better and more fitting that watching a film — whose main purpose is certainly pleasure, release, relaxation and a measure of disconnection — should also constitute, to some extent, an intellectual activity (the degree, of course, depending on the nature of the film), if we reflect and analyze a little on the experience the actors went through (and that we identified with), or on the experience we ourselves went through as viewers — where exactly was the delight for us here, out of what did this delight arise, what is its source within our soul, and what can we do with this life-force: develop it, refine it, place it within a general moral context regarding life as a whole, regarding doing good and repairing the world, and so on. Powerful feelings are food for spiritual digestion, they are an opening to thought and inspiration, to maturation and to better self-understanding.